

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, APRIL 27, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Shooting suspect aired grudges

Man sent anti-Trump writings just before DC attack, one official says

By Eric Tucker, Alanna Durkin Richer and Michael Balsamo
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The man accused of opening fire at the White House Correspondents’ Association dinner railed against Trump administration policies and referred to himself as a “Friendly Federal Assassin” in writings sent to family members minutes before the attack that authorities increasingly believe was politically motivated, according to a law enforcement official familiar with the investigation.

The writings, sent shortly before shots were fired Saturday night at the Washington Hilton, made repeated references to President Donald Trump without naming him directly and alluded to grievances over a range of administration actions and recent events, including U.S. strikes on drug smuggling boats, the official said Sunday.

The official was not authorized to discuss the ongoing investigation and spoke on condition of anonymity.

Investigators are treating the writings, along with a trail of social media posts and interviews with family members, as some of the clearest evidence yet of the suspect’s mindset and possible motives.

Authorities also uncovered what the official described as numerous anti-Trump social media posts linked to the suspect, Cole Tomas Allen, a 31-year-old California man accused of trying to breach a security checkpoint at the dinner while armed with multiple weapons.

Allen’s brother contacted police in New London, Connecticut, after receiving the writings, according to the official. In a statement, the

See **SUSPECT** on Page A9

MORE COVERAGE: Trump called for healing after confronting what he saw as a third attempt on his life in less than two years. **Page B1**



Nora Draniczarek and her son Joe, 3, tie blue ribbons down the block Sunday in Edison Park for a neighbor, Chicago police Officer John Bartholomew, who was shot and killed Saturday at Endeavor Health Swedish Hospital. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘KINDNESS, THAT’S ALL HE KNEW’

Chicago police officer fatally shot at Swedish Hospital remembered as ‘extremely generous’ public servant; second officer in critical condition

By Talia Soglin, Audrey Pachuta and Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A knack for public service was one of Chicago police Officer John Bartholomew’s defining qualities, friends and neighbors recalled Sunday.

Bartholomew, 38, who had been with the police department for a decade, was identified by the Cook County medical examiner’s office as the officer fatally shot Saturday morning at a North Side hospital.

He was shot alongside a 57-year-old officer who was in critical condition as of Saturday afternoon.

Richard Hudock said he grew up on the same Morton Grove street as the Bartholomew family and became lifelong friends with John and his brother, Jim. The three boys spent their childhood playing video games together, and though they have grown and taken on a plethora of adult responsibilities, it’s a hobby they have never given up, he said.

The last time Hudock said he spoke to Bartholomew, on April 22, they planned a trip to Galloping Ghost Arcade in Brookfield for May.

“It’s so sudden he’s gone now,” he said through tears. “And now I’m just never gonna see him again.”

Hudock described Bartholomew as “extremely generous” and having “the highest morals” of anyone he had ever met.

The 44-year-old Evanston resident recalled a difficult period in his life when he struggled with his mental health and finances. He remembers fondly a simple moment when he could not afford a \$75 ball for his bowling league, and Bartholomew gave him \$100 to cover the cost.

“He always just found a way to lift my spirits. He was a major shoulder for me to lean on,” Hudock said. “I don’t know if I would have made it through that terrible part of my life without him.”

Though the friends have seen each other only a few times a year recently, they always spoke on the phone at least once a month.

Hudock described Bartholomew as an excellent father to his daughter and stepsons and a supportive “family man” to his wife Renee, whom he married last summer.

“Kindness, that’s all he knew,” he said.

On the block in Edison Park where Bartholomew lived, neighbors and a crew of their young children tied blue ribbons on trees and railings Sunday morning.

Neighbors described the block

See **OFFICER** on Page A5

Poll: Most Chicagoans opposed crackdown

Suffolk-Tribune survey finds strong opposition to immigration raids, fears of agents at polls

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicagoans overwhelmingly opposed last fall’s federal immigration crackdown and the aggressive tactics used to carry it out, and amid President Donald Trump’s deep unpopularity among city residents, most residents are concerned he will deploy federal agents near polling places in November, a new poll shows.

The Suffolk University/Chicago Tribune survey of 500 adult city residents, conducted April 11-15, found a sizable majority saying there was no need for federal Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents and members of Customs and Border Protection to return to the city. But they were more closely divided over whether the city should keep its “sanctuary status”



U.S. Border Patrol agents detain a person while residents and activists protest in Chicago’s Brighton Park neighborhood on Oct. 4, 2025. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

for immigrants if it would mean a loss of federal dollars. Conducted by David Paleologos, director of Suffolk University’s Political Research Center, the poll carries an overall margin of error of 4.4 percentage points.

Three-quarters of city residents said they strongly or somewhat disapproved of the Department of Homeland Security’s Operation Midway Blitz immigration enforcement program last fall, including two-thirds who said they strongly disapproved. Fewer than 1 in 5 Chicagoans said they supported the operation, and only 10% strongly approved.

A Tribune analysis last month found roughly 3,800 people were detained and nearly 2,500 immigrants were deported during the operation, most of them with no criminal record despite Trump’s vow that the operation targeted “the worst of the worst” criminals in the country illegally.

The poll found opposition to Operation Midway Blitz from 72% of white respondents, 68% of Latinos and 63% of Black residents, as well as 88% of those who said they were Democrats and 57% of those who call themselves independents. Of

See **POLL** on Page A2

Teen charged in Chicago was part of international hacker group, feds say

19-year-old accused of participating in Scattered Spider ransom attacks

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The high-tech cyber hacker who goes by the online moniker “Bouquet” jetted around the world, from Dubai to Thailand to New York, staying in five-star hotels and flashing cash and jewels, federal authorities allege.

As his internet attacks grew bolder and more sophisticated, he taunted the FBI for being a step behind, authorities allege, posted memes depicting his crew as mafia bosses

and photos of himself wearing a diamond-studded necklace that spelled out in giant letters “HACK THE PLANET.”

Now, the feds say, “Bouquet” has been busted. His real name is Peter Stokes, a dual citizen of the U.S. and Estonia who was arrested earlier this month in Finland attempting to board a flight to Japan, according to court records obtained by the Tribune.

Perhaps most surprising? He’s only 19.

Federal charges filed under seal in Chicago allege Stokes is a prolific member of a loosely connected, international group of sophisticated hackers known as Scattered Spider, and that he

See **CHARGED** on Page A4

SPORTS

A look at Bears’ first draft picks

After months of scouting and preparation, the Bears drafted seven players over the weekend. Safety Dillon Thieneman should start for coach Ben Johnson’s defense right away. But the rest of the picks will have a harder path toward playing time. **Page C1**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 69 L: 51
TUE. H: 63 L: 46
WED. H: 56 L: 41
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A9
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A6
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A9
Television B7

178th year No. 117
© Chicago Tribune

